

THE WATER CARRIER

Aquarius



SIZE RANKING 10

BRIGHTEST STARS
 Sadalmelik (α) 2.9,
 Sadalsuud (β) 2.9

GENITIVE
 Aquarii

ABBREVIATION Aqr

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
 June–July

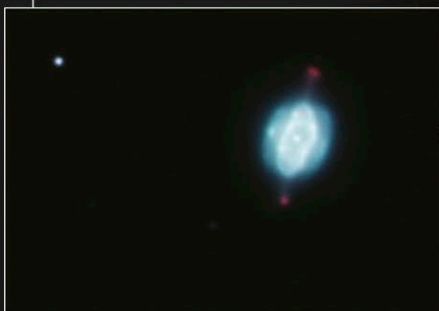
FULLY VISIBLE
 65°N–86°S


This large constellation of the zodiac is visualized as a youth (or, sometimes, an older man) pouring water from a jar. It is found between Capricornus and Pisces, near the celestial equator. The stars Gamma (γ), Zeta (ζ), Eta (η), and Pi (π) Aquarii form a Y-shaped grouping that makes up the Water Jar, from which a stream of stars represents water flowing toward Piscis Austrinus. In early May each year, the Eta Aquariid meteor shower radiates from the area of the water jar.

In Greek myths and stories, Aquarius represents Ganymede—a beautiful shepherd boy to whom the god Zeus took a liking to. Zeus dispatched his eagle (or, in some stories, turned himself into an eagle) to carry Ganymede up to Mount Olympus, where he became a cup bearer to the gods. The Eagle is represented by neighboring Aquila.

THE SATURN NEBULA ♄ ♀

NGC 7009's resemblance to the ringed planet Saturn is most evident when it is viewed through a large telescope or on a CCD image.

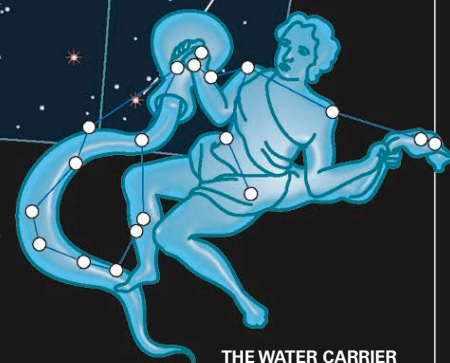
**SPECIFIC FEATURES**

Zeta—the star at the center of the Water Jar group—is a close binary of 4th-magnitude stars just at the limit of resolution with a telescope of 2.4 in (60 mm) aperture. Located near the border with Equuleus, the globular cluster M2 appears as a fuzzy star when viewed through binoculars or a small telescope.

Aquarius contains two of the best-known planetary nebulae in the sky. The Helix Nebula (NGC 7293; see p.257) is thought to be the closest planetary nebula to Earth, being about 650 light-years away. It is therefore one of the largest of such

nebulae in apparent size, at almost half the diameter of a full moon. However, because its light is spread over such a large area, the Helix Nebula can be identified only when skies are clear and dark. Visually, this nebula appears as a pale gray patch, showing none of the beautiful colors captured on photographs.

The second planetary nebula—the Saturn Nebula (NGC 7009)—is easier to spot, appearing to be of a size similar to the disk of Saturn when viewed with a small telescope. Its faint extensions on either side, rather like the rings of Saturn, give rise to the object's popular name.



THE WATER CARRIER

THE HELIX NEBULA ♈ ♀

NGC 7293 is visible as a pale rounded patch through binoculars under dark skies, but its detailed structure and approximate colors are brought out in CCD images such as this.

**POURING WATER** ☞

The cascade of stars that represent the flow of water from Aquarius's jar is to the left of this image. The distinctive Water Jar is center-top.